

THE MURDER OF FIVE CHILDREN A WALTHAMSTOW.

At the Stratford Petty Sessions on Saturday, in the Court-house of the Half-hundred of Becontree Division William Gouldstone, 26, of 8, Courtney-place, St. James's street, Walthamstow, was again brought up on the charge of murdering his five children on the 8th inst., at his residence, under circumstances already reported. At the inquest held on Monday last the jury returned a verdict of wilful murder against the prisoner. Mr. Ratcliff, from the office of the Solicitor to the Treasury, now appeared to prosecute on behalf of the Public Prosecutor, and Mr. Atkinson, a local solicitor, watched the case for the prisoner. Mrs. Ada Hamilton, the nurse to Mrs. Gouldstone in her confinement, and who has already given evidence, was again called, and, cross-examined by Mr. Atkinson, she simply added to her previous statement that after August 1, 1882, Mrs. Gouldstone was confined of twins the prisoner appeared to be in a desponding state and absent-minded. He would come in and sit down, but seldom spoke. She had never heard him complain of being short of money, or of being unable to support his children. He was very kind to his wife, and she never heard him speak a cross word to her. She had never heard the wife say that she wished the children dead. Prisoner did not say anything to her on the Sunday before this occurrence that he felt a fit of kleptomania coming over him. When he was sitting on the fire guard with his back to the fire he was twisting a bit of cord in his hands. He was not gazing absently into the fire. There might have been a slip of cord in the cord at the time but she did not notice it. She had not seen him going about muttering to himself since August 1. When she saw him carrying the first child from the washhouse to the kitchen he seemed very excited, not absent or wandering.

P. C. Cheeseman, 88 N. was next recalled, and having repeated that he was called to the house of the prisoner at the time of the murder, said:—I went into the prisoner's kitchen—they live upstairs—and saw three children lying on the floor there. The prisoner was standing over them in a stooping position. He had his hat and coat off, his shirt sleeves being tucked up. The children's clothes appeared to be drenched with water; they were thoroughly wet. When the prisoner saw me he said, "Good evening, police man; I have done it; now I am happy and ready for the rope." I cautioned him, telling him that whatever he said would be used in evidence against him. Having put on his hat and coat he asked me to let him see his wife, and I then took him into the bedroom. His wife said, "Oh, you wicked man; what have you done?" and he replied, "I have killed all your children, you will be single again and I shall be hanged." She then asked him for some money, and he gave her all he had. He then kissed his wife, wished her "goodbye," and I took him away from the house. On the road to the police-station prisoner said: "When I took my money last week I thought of buying a revolver to do it with, but I altered my mind, as I thought it would make too much noise. I had a hard job with the two biggest, but the other little ones, I soon settled him. I thought it was getting too hot, I have had five—kiss in three years and a-half, so I thought it was time to put on a stop to it." At the station prisoner said: "I did it like a man" and when he was charged he remarked: "Quite right, Sir." When I saw the three children at the house I startled myself that they were dead.

Cross-examined, witness said prisoner seemed excited at the time, but not from drink. When he spoke about being ready for the rope, he did not have a piece of cord in his hand. He did not hear Mrs. Gouldstone remark in her bedroom that she wished the children were dead. As a matter of fact the whole of the children at that time were not dead. It was at the station, prisoner said: "Quite right, Sir." He made no mention about not having money to support the children. The wife made no reply whatever when he said he had murdered all her children.

Police-constable Henry, 41 N. Recorro, and Inspector Folcard, repeated the evidence they had previously given, the latter adding that he had examined the sisters. The top of it was about 6ft. from the floor, and 10in. from the ceiling. It was 14in. deep.

Police-constable Wintley, 208 N. stationed at Lea-bridge-road, said:—At about quarter to 7 o'clock on the evening of the 8th inst. I was in a passage at the station, leading to the cell where the prisoner was. He said to me: "I have had an extra drop of drink today to accomplish this job. There's five of them to go to glory, and it is a good job too." At half-past 7 o'clock he said: "I am sorry for my wife and parents, but the children will be better off in Heaven, if there is such a place." It is better than leaving them to the mercy of the world." At about 9 o'clock he said: "I wish I had killed the little ones out of the way. I do not know if I hit them once or twice. I have had this prying on my mind for a long time."

By Mr. Atkinson.—He volunteered these statements. He was under my immediate observation all the time. I did not hear him rambling or mumbling to himself. I observed no trace of drink about him. I did not in the least observe any strangeness about him; he was very cool.

Mr. Henry Gould, M.R.C.S., L.A.S. Imd., the divisional surgeon of police for the district, said:—On the 8th inst., at about 6 o'clock, I was called by Inspector Folcard, and went with him to 8, Courtney-place. I went into the front room on the first floor, and on a bed saw two male children, only a few days old. I examined them, and found they had both received injuries to the head. I felt that the skull of each was fractured, and that blood and flesh was coming from them. I saw it was impossible that they could live. In the kitchen I saw three children lying side by side, quite dead. I saw no marks of violence on two of them, but on the eldest I found an indentation mark of stout cord that had been put around the neck. At 7 the same evening one of the infants died, and the next morning when I went to the house at about 7 o'clock I found the other had succumbed. Since then I have made post-mortem examinations. As to the two younger children, I found that death had been caused by the violence that fractured the skull. As to the three others, they died from suffocation caused by burning. All the clothes of the children were well nigh shed.

By Mr. Atkinson.—I have only seen the prisoner in connection with this case. I should not like to say that I am personally acquainted with the "Cyclopedia of Practical Medicine."

Mr. Atkinson (to Mr. Wells, the clerk).—I have a long street, will you take it down.

Mr. Wells.—It is outside evidence, I presume, I wait the order of the bench.

Mr. Gould said he was afraid that he was not well up in questions of insanity, to which, he presumed, the questions referred, as it was a specialty.

Mr. Ratcliff said that, as Mr. Wells had remarked, insanity was not a question for the consideration of the jury, if information were wanted by Mr. Atkinson he could have evidence produced at the trial.

Mr. Atkinson said he only desired to get a few words in the depositions before the case went before a Judge and jury. He was in the hall of the Bench, however, and they dissented, he would have to get the questions put through counsel at another place.

The Bench having dissented to the cross-examination, Mr. Ratcliff said this was his case.

Dr. Gould was, however, recalled by Mr. Ester, and reply to a question, said he was not aware if any means had been taken to restore animation in the three children, or whether they had been at the house before 8 p.m.

The prisoner was then committed to take his trial at the Central Criminal Court, reserving his defence.

During the proceedings the prisoner assumed an air of perfect indifference. Subsequently, however, on being tried in his cell by Miss Skinner, a lady who is doing odd work in the neighbourhood in connection with Mrs. May's Refuge Home, the prisoner manifested a resistant mood. The police had much difficulty in getting him away from the station without his being seen by the large crowd who had assembled in the neighbourhood, and so evidently were much incensed against him.